Thursday, November 5, 2026

St. Irenaeus of Lyons

Bishop, Father and Doctor of the Church · Feast, June 28



Saint Irénée, stained glass by Lucien Bégule, 1901, Église Saint-Irénée, Lyon[1]

1. Lucien Bégule, *Saint Irénée*, stained-glass window, 1901, Église Saint-Irénée, Lyon; photograph by Gérald Gambier, 2010.

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Proconsular Asia (western Asia Minor, today's Turkey), or a province bordering it.[2] As a young man in Smyrna he saw and heard St. Polycarp,[3] who had himself been a disciple of St. John the Apostle.[4]
- **Born:** first half of the second century. Scholars disagree: some say between 115 and 125, others between 130 and 142.[5]
- **Died:** the date is unknown, at the end of the second century or the beginning of the third.[6] Later tradition calls him a martyr, but the Catholic Encyclopedia judges it "not very probable that he ended his career with martyrdom."[7]
- **Feast:** June 28 in the Latin Church, August 23 in the Greek.[8]
- **Doctor of the Church:** declared by Pope Francis on January 21, 2022,[9] who called him a "Doctor of Unity" because his teaching "is like a bridge between East and West."[10]
- **Patron:** of apologists and catechists.[11]

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2. "St. Irenaeus," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 8 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910).
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. Ibid.
7. Ibid.
8. Ibid.
9. Francis, Decree naming St. Irenaeus of Lyon a Doctor of the Church (January 21, 2022), as reported by the Dicastery for Promoting Christian Unity, "Saint Irenaeus of Lyon, Doctor unitatis," January 24, 2022.
10. Ibid.
11. Our Sunday Visitor Staff, "St. Irenaeus," *Our Sunday Visitor*, June 28, 2023.

✠ His Life in Brief

Irenaeus was a priest of the Church of Lyons in Gaul during the persecution under Marcus Aurelius.[12] In 177 or 178 the clergy of Lyons, many of them in prison for the faith, sent him to Rome with a letter to Pope Eleutherius.[13] He came back to succeed the martyred St. Pothinus as bishop.[14]

- His chief work, *Against Heresies*, exposes and refutes Gnosticism, the "secret knowledge" movement of his day.[15]
- His *Proof of the Apostolic Preaching* explains the faith to believers.[16]
- In 190 or 191 he asked Pope Victor to lift the excommunication of the churches of Asia Minor over the date of Easter, a peacemaker true to his name.[17]

✠ Famous Excerpt: *Against Heresies* 4.20.7

> *"For the glory of God is a living man; and the life of man consists in beholding God. For if the manifestation of God which is made by means of the creation, affords life to all living in the earth, much more does that revelation of the Father which comes through the Word, give life to those who see God."*[18]

12. "St. Irenaeus," *Catholic Encyclopedia*.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* 4.20.7, trans. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson, and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: the one faith everywhere (the rule of faith). In *Against Heresies* Irenaeus summarized what the Church believed: "The Church, though dispersed throughout the whole world, even to the ends of the earth, has received from the apostles and their disciples this faith," and he lists belief in one God the Father Almighty, one Christ Jesus who became incarnate for our salvation, and the Holy Spirit.[19] The Catechism quotes him on this point: the Church "guards [this preaching and faith] with care, as dwelling in but a single house" (CCC 173).[20]

Exercise: set his summary next to the Apostles' Creed and have students find each article.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection 1: "The 'lost gospels' and secret teachings show the real Jesus that the Church hid." This was the Gnostic claim in Irenaeus's own day, and he answered it: "if the apostles had known hidden mysteries, which they were in the habit of imparting to the perfect apart and privily from the rest, they would have delivered them especially to those to whom they were also committing the Churches themselves."[21] The true teaching is public and traceable,

19. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* 1.10.1, trans. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson, and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).
20. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 173.
21. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* 3.3.1–3, trans. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson, and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885).

because we can "reckon up those who were by the apostles instituted bishops in the Churches."[22]

Objection 2: "The papacy and apostolic succession were invented centuries later." Writing as bishop of Lyons in the late second century, Irenaeus lists the bishops of Rome from the apostles, beginning with Linus,[23] and says: "it is a matter of necessity that every Church should agree with this Church, on account of its preeminent authority."[24] The Catechism cites this very passage (CCC 834).[25] Compare Mt 16:18 and 2 Tim 2:2.

✠ 3. Theology

- **God's glory and man's fulfillment:** The Catechism uses his words to explain why God created the world: "the glory of God is man fully alive; moreover man's life is the vision of God" (CCC 294).[26] God's glory and our happiness are not rivals.
- **Tradition and Scripture together:** Against teachers who claimed private revelations, Irenaeus points to the faith handed down publicly through the successions of bishops.[27]
- **A bridge between East and West:** Born in the East, bishop in the West, he is now honored as a "Doctor of Unity."[28]

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22. Ibid.
23. Ibid.
24. Ibid.
25. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 834.
26. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 294.
27. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.3.1–3.
28. Francis, Decree on St. Irenaeus.

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect for St. Irenaeus (Roman Missal, June 28):[29]
O God, who called the Bishop Saint Irenaeus to confirm true doctrine and the peace of the Church, grant, we pray, through his intercession, that, being renewed in faith and charity, we may always be intent on fostering unity and concord. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

Practice: Pray the Apostles' Creed slowly today, remembering that Irenaeus professed the same faith eighteen centuries ago.[30] Pray for Christian unity.

✠ Today's Takeaway

The faith we hold is not a secret for a few but the public, apostolic faith of the whole Church, and living it is how we give God glory: "the glory of God is a living man."[31]

St. Irenaeus, pray for us.

29. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, June 28, Saint Irenaeus, Collect.
30. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 1.10.1.
31. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 4.20.7.